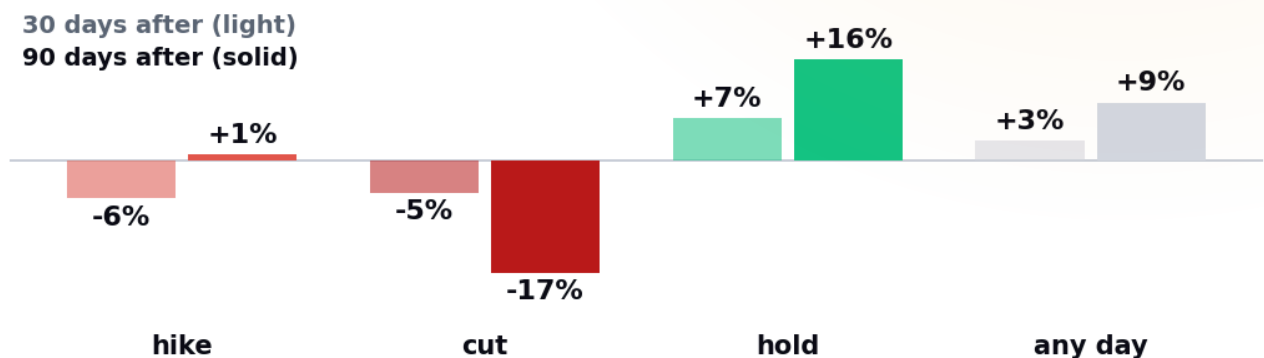


THE FED DECISION STUDY

Every scheduled Federal Reserve decision since 2015, 92 of them, graded against Bitcoin. The run-up into the meeting, then 7, 30, 60 and 90 days after, hikes, cuts and holds, against any random day.

The month after a hike, the cut that was worse than the hike, the hold that beat everything, and this week's decision by the base rates.



median Bitcoin return after every Fed decision since 2015. 20 hikes, 9 cuts, 63 holds, against any day.

3 of 20

hikes followed by a higher price 30 days later

2 of 9

cuts followed by a higher price 60 days later

66%

of holds higher 90 days later

Educational, not financial advice. The calendar and the outcomes come from public records, the base rate sits next to every figure, and twenty hikes and nine cuts are small samples and are treated as such.



Bitcoin Jae
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THE TEST

HOW EVERY DECISION WAS GRADED

The Federal Open Market Committee meets eight times a year and announces its decision on a Wednesday afternoon, occasionally a Thursday. Each scheduled decision since January 2015 is one event. The outcome, hike, cut or hold, comes from the change in the Fed funds upper target as published by the St. Louis Fed, which dates changes the day after the announcement, so each meeting is matched to the change that lands within three days of it.

For every decision, Bitcoin's close 7 days before the meeting to the decision-day close is the run-up. Then the decision-day close to the close 7, 30, 60 and 90 days later. Bitstamp daily closes throughout. The base rate is the same window measured from every single day since 2015, so a Fed-day number only means something if it differs from that.

One event is deliberately not in the count. The emergency 100 basis point cut on 16 March 2020 fell on an unscheduled Sunday and is left out, because the study is about the scheduled decisions traders position for. It would have made the cut bucket look worse, not better.

THE COUNT

20 hikes, 9 cuts, 63 holds. Same ruler for all 92, then the three outcomes get separated.

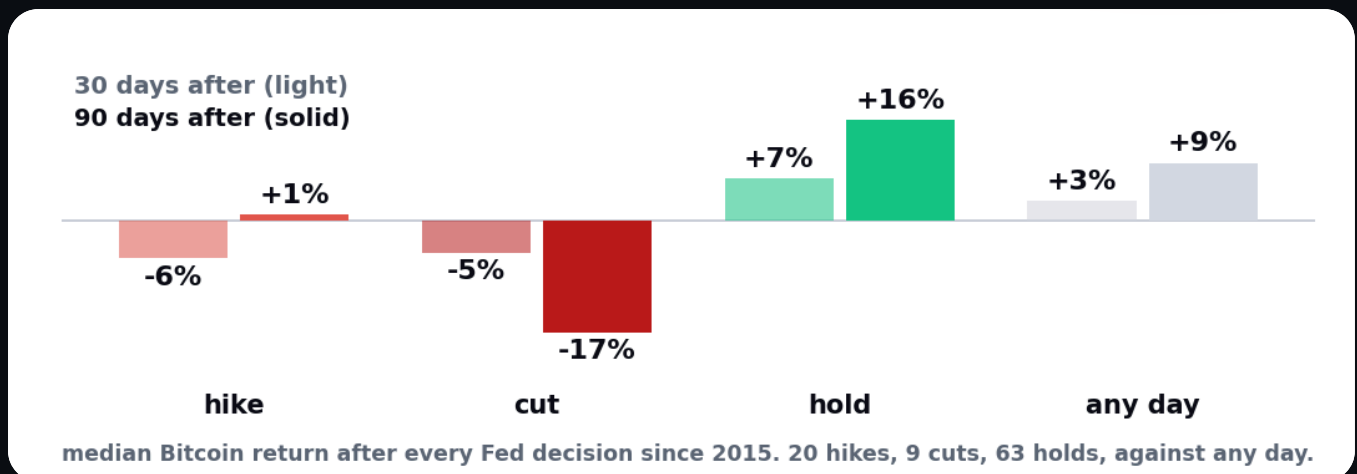
THE SCOREBOARD

HIKES, CUTS AND HOLDS AGAINST ANY DAY

OUTCOME	N	RUN-UP 7D	+7D	+30D, UP	+60D, UP	+90D, UP
hikes	20	+1.4%	-0.6%	-6.0% / 15%	-3.2% / 40%	+0.9% / 50%
cuts	9	+2.3%	-0.8%	-5.0% / 33%	-19.1% / 22%	-17.4% / 33%
holds	63	+1.5%	+0.3%	+6.5% / 63%	+10.1% / 66%	+15.6% / 66%
any day	4,247	+0.7%	+0.7%	+3.1% / 58%	+7.2% / 59%	+9.0% / 60%

Medians. 'up' = share of cases with a higher close. Any day = every day since 2015.

The run-up is real and small. Into a decision Bitcoin rose a median +1.9%, higher 61% of the time, against +0.7% for any week. The week after a decision, +0.2%, is noise. The month after is where the three outcomes come apart, and they come apart in a way the popular script gets backwards. The hike hurts for a month. The cut hurts for a quarter. The hold, the outcome nobody tweets about, beats a random day at every horizon.



HIKES

ALL 20 HIKES, AND THE MONTH AFTER

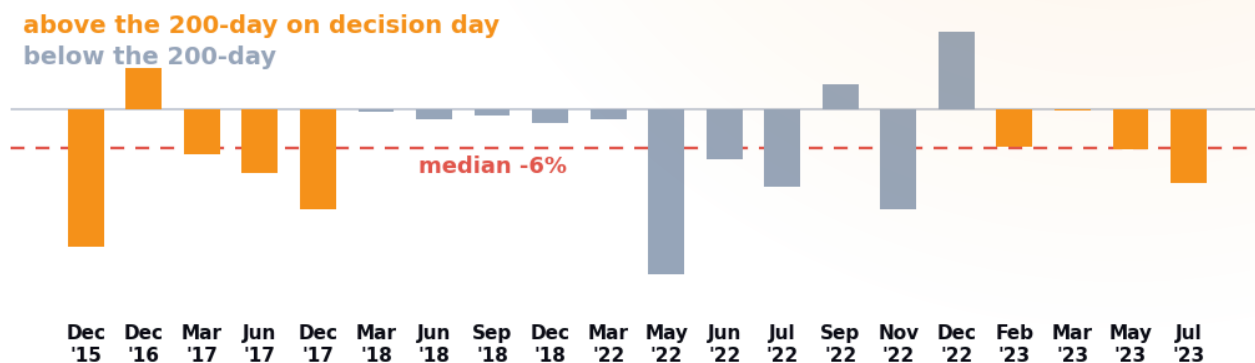
DECISION	SIZE	TREND	RUN-UP 7D	+7D	+30D	+60D	+90D
16 Dec 2015	25 bp	above	+9%	-3%	-21%	-11%	-9%
14 Dec 2016	25 bp	above	+2%	+7%	+6%	+29%	+60%
15 Mar 2017	25 bp	above	+9%	-17%	-7%	+42%	+115%
14 Jun 2017	25 bp	above	-9%	+8%	-10%	+65%	+70%
13 Dec 2017	25 bp	above	+19%	+1%	-15%	-50%	-44%
21 Mar 2018	25 bp	below	+9%	-11%	-0%	-4%	-24%
13 Jun 2018	25 bp	below	-18%	+7%	-1%	+0%	-0%
26 Sep 2018	25 bp	below	+1%	-0%	-1%	-39%	-41%
19 Dec 2018	25 bp	below	+7%	+3%	-2%	-2%	+9%
16 Mar 2022	25 bp	below	-2%	+4%	-1%	-24%	-46%
04 May 2022	50 bp	below	+1%	-27%	-25%	-51%	-42%
15 Jun 2022	75 bp	below	-25%	-11%	-8%	+8%	-11%
27 Jul 2022	75 bp	below	-1%	-1%	-12%	-18%	-13%
21 Sep 2022	75 bp	below	-9%	+5%	+4%	-12%	-8%
02 Nov 2022	75 bp	below	-3%	-21%	-15%	-18%	+15%
14 Dec 2022	50 bp	below	+6%	-5%	+12%	+22%	+39%
01 Feb 2023	25 bp	above	+3%	-3%	-6%	+19%	+21%
22 Mar 2023	25 bp	above	+12%	+4%	-0%	-2%	+4%
03 May 2023	25 bp	above	+2%	-5%	-6%	+5%	+2%
26 Jul 2023	25 bp	above	-2%	-1%	-11%	-11%	+16%

Trend = Bitcoin above or below its 200-day average on the decision day.

HIKES

THE MONTH AFTER A HIKE, AND THE TREND

Thirty days after a hike, Bitcoin was lower by a median 6%, and higher only 3 times in 20. That is the cleanest single number in the study. Ninety days out the picture splits by trend. Above the 200-day average the dip recovered, a median of +16% with 7 of 9 higher. Below it, -11% with 3 of 11 higher. A hike costs the month either way. Whether the month comes back depends on the trend the hike landed in, not on the hike.



Bitcoin 30 days after every Fed hike since 2015. Higher in 3 of 20.

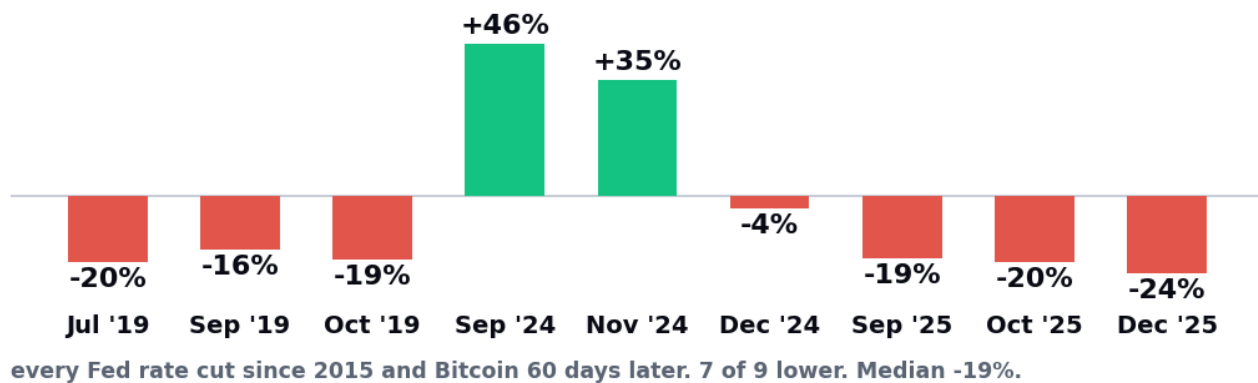
CUTS

ALL 9 CUTS, THE BULLISH ONE

DECISION	SIZE	TREND	RUN-UP 7D	+7D	+30D	+60D	+90D
31 Jul 2019	25 bp	above	+3%	+19%	-5%	-20%	-7%
18 Sep 2019	25 bp	above	-0%	-17%	-22%	-16%	-35%
30 Oct 2019	25 bp	above	+23%	+2%	-15%	-19%	+3%
18 Sep 2024	50 bp	below	+8%	+2%	+11%	+46%	+72%
07 Nov 2024	25 bp	above	+8%	+15%	+32%	+35%	+27%
18 Dec 2024	25 bp	above	-1%	-1%	+4%	-4%	-17%
17 Sep 2025	25 bp	above	+2%	-3%	-9%	-19%	-25%
29 Oct 2025	25 bp	above	+2%	-6%	-17%	-20%	-19%
10 Dec 2025	25 bp	below	-2%	-6%	-2%	-24%	-24%

The 2020 emergency cut is excluded as unscheduled.

Thirty days after a cut, a median -5%, higher 3 of 9. Sixty days, -19%, higher 2 of 9. Ninety days, -17%, higher 3 of 9. The three 2019 cuts led into the 2019 to 2020 slide. The three late-2025 cuts all led to a price 19 to 24% lower within 90 days. The one clean exception is September 2024, the half-point cut that preceded the election rally. A cut is what the Fed does when it sees damage the market has not priced. It is the diagnosis, not the medicine.



HOLDS, AND THE TREND

THE BORING OUTCOME, AND THE REGIME TABLE

63 of the 92 decisions changed nothing. Thirty days later Bitcoin was higher a median +6.5%, up 63% of the time. Ninety days later +15.6%, up 66%. Both beat any random day. A hold means nothing broke and nothing tightened, which is the only Fed setting Bitcoin has ever consistently liked.

OUTCOME AND TREND	N	+30D MEDIAN	+30D HIGHER	+90D MEDIAN	+90D HIGHER
hike, above the 200-day	9	-6.9%	1 of 9	+15.5%	7 of 9
hike, below the 200-day	11	-1.5%	2 of 11	-10.5%	3 of 11
cut, above the 200-day	7	-8.6%	2 of 7	-17.4%	2 of 7
cut, below the 200-day	2	+4.6%	1 of 2	+24.0%	1 of 2
hold, above the 200-day	42	+5.8%	27 of 42	+19.4%	30 of 42
hold, below the 200-day	21	+7.1%	13 of 21	+6.5%	11 of 20

Above or below the 200-day average on the decision day. Two cuts below the 200-day is two cuts, read it that way.

The regime column is the honest complication. Hikes in an uptrend recovered, hikes in a downtrend did not. Cuts in an uptrend were the worst cell on the whole board, because those cuts were the Fed reacting to a slowdown while the crowd was still bullish. Holds were fine in both. If you take one rule from the table, it is that the trend on the decision day told you more about the next quarter than the decision did.

THIS WEEK

WEDNESDAY, BY THE BASE RATES

The last five decisions, January to July 2026, were holds. Bitcoin is above its 200-day average as of this writing and below the last lower high of the bear at \$82,833, which is the structural definition this page has used all year. As of 14 September the market is pricing a 90% probability of a quarter-point hike to 3.75 to 4.00%, per CME FedWatch, against 10% for a hold.

If the Fed hikes, the base rate for the next month is red in 17 of 20 cases. Which regime bucket it belongs to is arguable, above the 200-day by the simple rule, below the last lower high by structure, and the two buckets disagree at 90 days. If the Fed holds, it is the one outcome in this study that argues against the pullback that every other base rate this month has pointed to. That is printed here because a study that only prints the numbers that help is not a study.

THE TEST

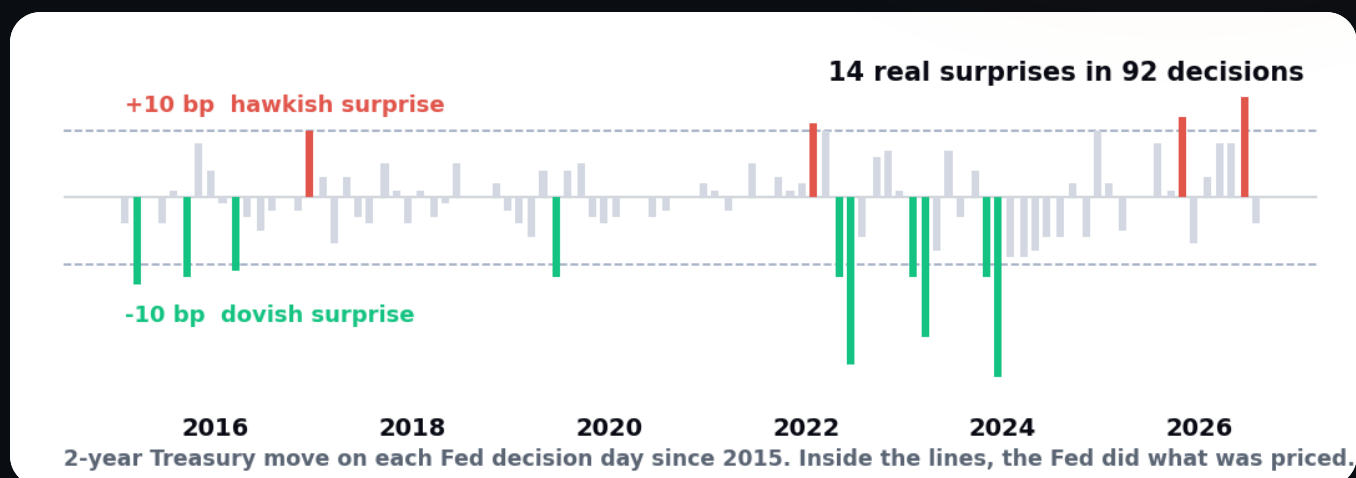
Whatever they do, the day after is noise. Grade the decision a month later, not an hour later. This is a study, not a call.

THE SURPRISE

WAS THE DECISION WHAT THE MARKET EXPECTED?

The rate itself is almost never the surprise. In the fed funds futures data that exists for 2015 to 2019, zero of forty scheduled decisions missed the futures by even five basis points. The famous coin flips, September 2015, June 2022 and September 2024, were repriced before the meeting. What surprises the market is the message, the statement, the dots and the press conference, and that is where Bitcoin moves.

So the surprise is measured on the 2-year Treasury yield, which prices the next eight meetings. If the Fed does what was priced, the 2-year barely moves on the day. If it jumps ten basis points or more, the decision or the message was not priced. On the 2015 to 2019 overlap this proxy has a 0.80 correlation with the Bauer and Swanson high-frequency surprise series, so it is a real measure, not a guess. Fourteen of the ninety-two decisions cleared ten basis points, about one in seven.

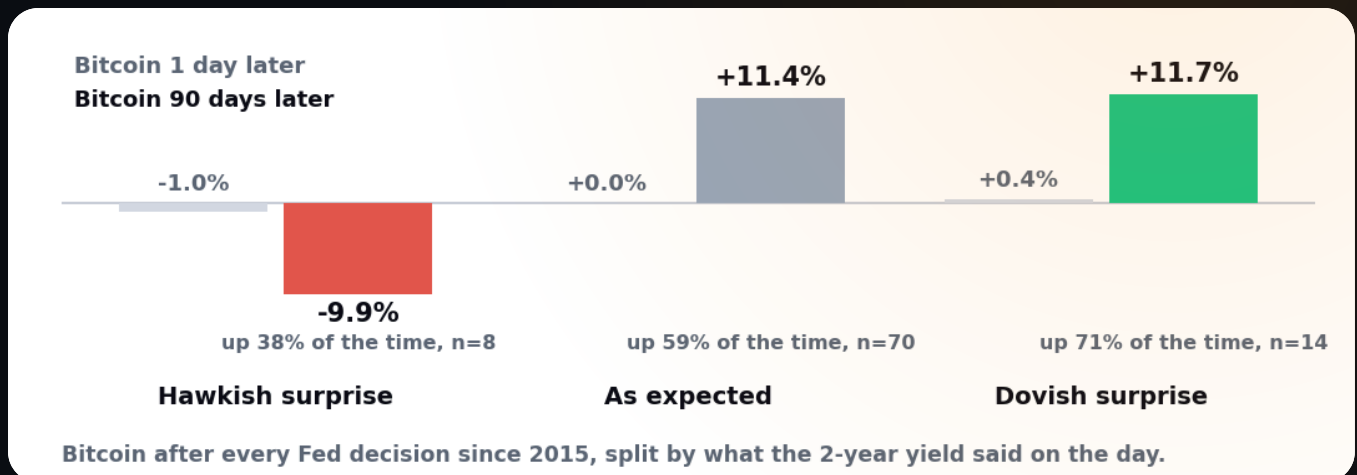


BUCKET (8 BP)	N	+1D	+7D	+30D / HIGHER	+90D / HIGHER
hawkish surprise (2y up 8 bp+)	8	-1.0%	-0.3%	-1.1% / 38%	-9.9% / 38%
as expected	70	+0.0%	-0.0%	+3.8% / 53%	+11.4% / 59%
dovish surprise (2y down 8 bp+)	14	+0.4%	+0.6%	-0.2% / 43%	+11.7% / 71%
any day	4,247		+0.7%	+3.1% / 58%	+9.0% / 60%

Medians. Hawkish = the 2-year rose 8 bp or more on the day, dovish = it fell 8 bp or more, as expected = inside.

THE SURPRISE

DAY ONE IS **NOTHING**, DAY NINETY IS THE SPLIT



Bitcoin's median move the day after a decision is zero in every bucket. The split shows up over ninety days, and only one bucket is red, the hawkish surprise, eight cases, median -9.9% and higher 38% of the time. The dovish surprise, fourteen cases, was the best, +11.7% and higher 71%.

The hike everyone saw coming is the worst next month on the board. Thirteen hikes were fully priced, and a month later Bitcoin was red 11 of 13 times, median -6.9%. The hold that surprised is the other side, nine times the Fed held and sounded softer than priced, and ninety days later Bitcoin was +21.2%, higher 7 of 9. The exception that matters is May and June 2022, hikes that surprised dovish while Bitcoin still fell 25% and 8% inside a month, because the bear was already running. A dovish Fed does not cancel a bear market.

THE SURPRISE

THE FOURTEEN REAL SURPRISES

Every decision day since 2015 where the 2-year Treasury moved ten basis points or more, with the decision the Fed made and what Bitcoin did after. Read the sign of the 2-year move as the direction of the surprise. Down is dovish, the Fed did or said less than the market feared. Up is hawkish.

DECISION DAY	DECISION	2-YEAR MOVE	+1D	+7D	+30D	+90D
18 Mar 2015	hold	-13 bp	+2%	-4%	-13%	-2%
17 Sep 2015	hold	-12 bp	+0%	+1%	+16%	+96%
16 Mar 2016	hold	-11 bp	+0%	+0%	+3%	+64%
14 Dec 2016	hike	+10 bp	-0%	+7%	+6%	+60%
19 Jun 2019	hold	-12 bp	+3%	+39%	+14%	+10%
26 Jan 2022	hold	+11 bp	+1%	+0%	+7%	+4%
04 May 2022	hike	-12 bp	-8%	-27%	-25%	-42%
15 Jun 2022	hike	-25 bp	-10%	-11%	-8%	-11%
01 Feb 2023	hike	-12 bp	-1%	-3%	-6%	+21%
22 Mar 2023	hike	-21 bp	+4%	+4%	-0%	+4%
01 Nov 2023	hold	-12 bp	-1%	+1%	+9%	+21%
13 Dec 2023	hold	-27 bp	+0%	+2%	-0%	+67%
29 Oct 2025	cut	+12 bp	-2%	-6%	-17%	-19%
17 Jun 2026	hold	+15 bp	-2%	-5%	-1%	+20%

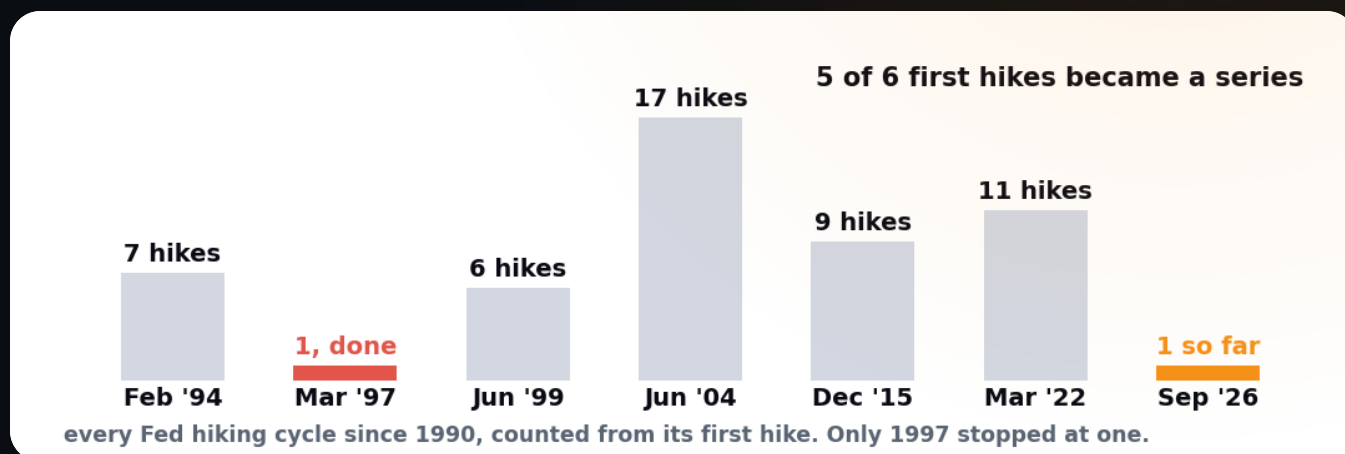
The June 2026 hold has no 90-day result yet. Medians in the bucket table use every case with data.

Two things stand out. Ten of the fourteen were dovish, so the Fed has surprised soft far more often than hard. And the dovish surprises inside the 2022 bear, May and June, were the worst outcomes on the page, which is the whole reason the trend on the decision day is printed next to every figure in this study.

THE SECOND HIKE

A FIRST HIKE IS ALMOST NEVER THE ONLY HIKE

On 16 September 2026 the Fed raised the target for the first time in 1,147 days, the first hike since July 2023 and the first after a run of cuts, and said a second hike was possible. That is a first hike of a cycle by definition. There have been six of those since 1990, counted as any hike with no hike in the prior year, using the Fed's own target series.



FIRST HIKE	SECOND WITHIN 6 MONTHS	HIKES IN THE CYCLE	TOTAL
04 Feb 1994	yes, 46 days	7	300 bp
25 Mar 1997	no, 827 days	1	25 bp
30 Jun 1999	yes, 55 days	6	175 bp
30 Jun 2004	yes, 41 days	17	425 bp
16 Dec 2015	no, 364 days	9	225 bp
17 Mar 2022	yes, 49 days	11	525 bp
16 Sep 2026	pending	1 so far	25 bp

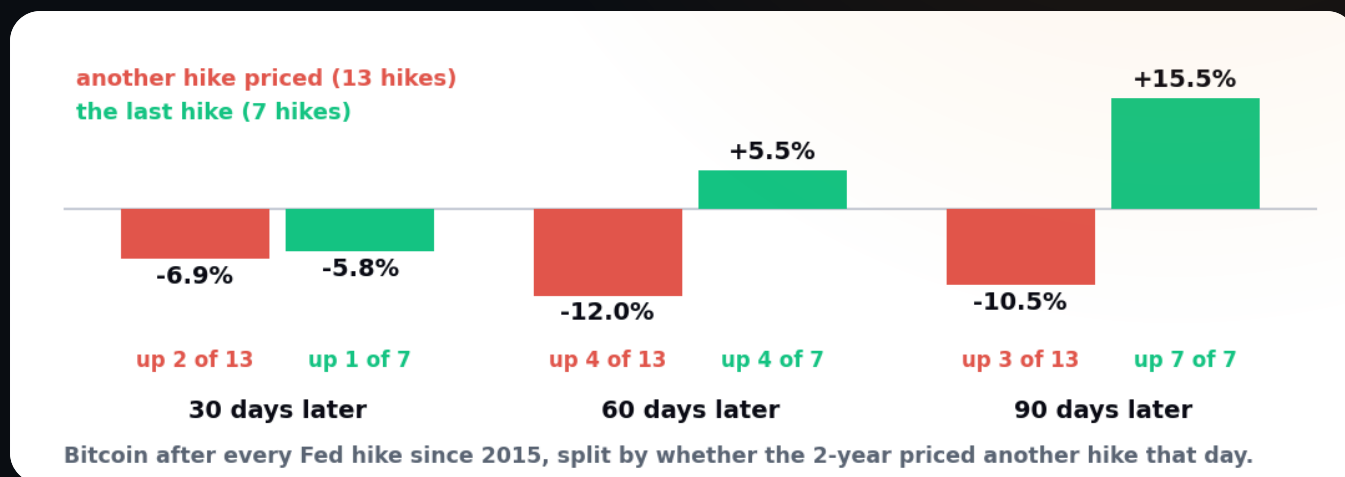
Cycle = every hike until a gap of more than a year. Source FRED DFEDTAR and DFEDTARU.

Five of the six became a series, median eight hikes and about 260 basis points. Four of the six delivered the second hike inside two months. The only one-and-done was March 1997. A possible second hike is not the risk case. It is the base case, and the honest reading of yesterday is to plan for several.

THE SECOND HIKE

WHEN THE MARKET EXPECTS MORE, BITCOIN HAS NOT LIKED IT

Whether the market expects another hike is priced, not guessed. The 2-year Treasury yield averages what the market thinks the Fed will do over two years. If it sits a full hike, 25 basis points or more, above the new target on the decision day, the market is pricing more. If it sits at or below the target, the market thinks the Fed is done. On the twenty Bitcoin-era hikes the 2-year priced another hike thirteen times.



BUCKET	N	+30D / HIGHER	+60D / HIGHER	+90D / HIGHER
another hike priced (gap 25 bp+)	13	-6.9% / 2 of 13	-12.0% / 4 of 13	-10.5% / 3 of 13
the last hike (gap under 25 bp)	7	-5.8% / 1 of 7	+5.5% / 4 of 7	+15.5% / 7 of 7

Medians. The seven 'done' hikes are the ends of the 2017, 2018 and 2023 cycles.

When the market expected more hikes, Bitcoin was lower three months later ten of thirteen times, median -10.5%. When the market believed the Fed was done, it was higher seven of seven, median +15.5%. Bitcoin has bottomed when the Fed finished, not when it started. The 2-year closed at 4.67% the day before this decision against a new 4.00% target, a 67 basis point gap that prices two or three more hikes. By the market's own pricing the September 2026 hike sits in the red bucket. Thirteen and seven are thin, the 2-year carries a term premium, and the two first hikes Bitcoin has lived through went opposite ways, December 2015 into a bull market and March 2022 into a bear. Read it as a lean, and watch the gap. When it closes, the Fed is done.

THE SECOND HIKE

ALL 20 HIKES AND THE 2-YEAR GAP

HIKE	2-YEAR	NEW TARGET	GAP	MARKET SAID	+30D	+90D
16 Dec 2015	1.02%	0.50%	+52 bp	more	-21%	-9%
14 Dec 2016	1.27%	0.75%	+52 bp	more	+6%	+60%
15 Mar 2017	1.33%	1.00%	+33 bp	more	-7%	+115%
14 Jun 2017	1.35%	1.25%	+10 bp	done	-10%	+70%
13 Dec 2017	1.79%	1.50%	+29 bp	more	-15%	-44%
21 Mar 2018	2.31%	1.75%	+56 bp	more	-0%	-24%
13 Jun 2018	2.59%	2.00%	+59 bp	more	-1%	-0%
26 Sep 2018	2.83%	2.25%	+58 bp	more	-1%	-41%
19 Dec 2018	2.63%	2.50%	+13 bp	done	-2%	+9%
16 Mar 2022	1.95%	0.50%	+145 bp	more	-1%	-46%
04 May 2022	2.66%	1.00%	+166 bp	more	-25%	-42%
15 Jun 2022	3.20%	1.75%	+145 bp	more	-8%	-11%
27 Jul 2022	2.96%	2.50%	+46 bp	more	-12%	-13%
21 Sep 2022	4.02%	3.25%	+77 bp	more	+4%	-8%
02 Nov 2022	4.61%	4.00%	+61 bp	more	-15%	+15%
14 Dec 2022	4.23%	4.50%	-27 bp	done	+12%	+39%
01 Feb 2023	4.09%	4.75%	-66 bp	done	-6%	+21%
22 Mar 2023	3.96%	5.00%	-104 bp	done	-0%	+4%
03 May 2023	3.89%	5.25%	-136 bp	done	-6%	+2%
26 Jul 2023	4.82%	5.50%	-68 bp	done	-11%	+16%

2-year Treasury constant-maturity yield on the decision day (FRED DGS2) against the new upper target. Gap of 25 bp or more = another hike priced.

The 2022 gaps are the largest on the page because the market was pricing a whole series at once, and those were the worst Bitcoin outcomes. The 2023 gaps turned negative one hike after the other, the market calling the end before the Fed did, and those were the best. The gap is a cleaner read of the Fed's path than any sentence in the statement.

WHAT THIS STUDY DOES NOT SAY

Twenty hikes and nine cuts. Medians on samples that size describe the middle of a wide spread. The hold bucket is the only one large enough to lean on, and even it spans two bull markets and three bears.

The Fed is not the only thing happening. Every decision sits inside a market that would have moved anyway. The base-rate column is there to separate the Fed's day from an ordinary day, and the regime table is there to separate the Fed from the trend. Neither fully does.

Bitcoin has only existed through one full hiking cycle and two easing cycles. 2015 to 2018, 2022 to 2023, and the cuts of 2019, 2024 and 2025. That is the whole record. Treat every figure as a lean, not a law.

Data pinned 17 September 2026. Surprise chapter added on decision day, second-hike chapter the day after. FOMC calendar from the Bitcoin Daily event-study harness; outcomes from FRED series DFEDTARU; prices Bitstamp BTC/USD daily closes. Scripts: FOMC/fomc_study.py, fomc_charts.py, fomc_surprise.py, fs_charts.py, second_hike.py, sh_charts.py. FRED DGS2 for the 2-year, DFEDTAR and DFEDTARU for the target. This is education, not financial advice.

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